

Initial Placement for Fruchterman–Reingold Force Model with Coordinate Newton Direction

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Abstract

The Fruchterman–Reingold (FR) force model is widely used in force-directed graph drawing, and multilevel approaches such as `sfdp` in Graphviz scale these methods effectively. A crucial step in multilevel schemes is refinement, which improves the graph layout typically performed with the FR algorithm. For this refinement, optimization-based methods, such as L-BFGS, often yield better layouts by exploiting past gradient information. However, they suffer from high per-iteration costs for large graphs and difficulty in handling highly twisted graphs.

In this research, we propose a new initial placement based on the stochastic coordinate descent to accelerate the optimization process. We first reformulate the problem as a discrete optimization problem using a hexagonal lattice and then iteratively update a randomly selected vertex along the coordinate Newton direction with low per-iteration costs.

We demonstrate the effectiveness of our method through numerical experiments, showing that our initial placement leads to faster convergence and higher-quality layouts compared to naive optimization approaches. We also discuss how the coordinate Newton direction can be applied to other graph-related problems from an optimization perspective.

1 Introduction

Graph drawing is a fundamental task in information visualization, and force-directed methods are among the most widely used approaches. In these methods, vertices are treated as particles subject to forces, and the resulting equilibrium layouts are regarded as desirable visualizations. Among established force models [9, 22], the Fruchterman–Reingold (FR) force model [11] is particularly prominent for its intuitive formulation, flexibility, and simplicity. It is implemented in libraries such as NetworkX [16], Graphviz [10], and igraph [7].

A central challenge in force-directed graph drawing is efficiently obtaining an equilibrium state of the force system. In force-directed methods, the refinement process iteratively adjusts vertex positions to reduce force imbalance, and its efficiency strongly affects both the computational cost and the quality of the visualization. This refinement remains important even in multilevel approaches such as the Scalable Force-Directed Placement (`sfdp`) algorithm [10, 21], where layouts must still be refined while propagating solutions from coarse to fine graph levels. See also Sec. 6.1 for more discussion.

Two major approaches are commonly used for refinement. The first is direct force simulation, typified by the FR algorithm [11], which repeatedly applies the forces to approximate equilibrium. The second is numerical optimization based on explicit energy minimization. In particular, the L-BFGS algorithm [24], a general-purpose optimization

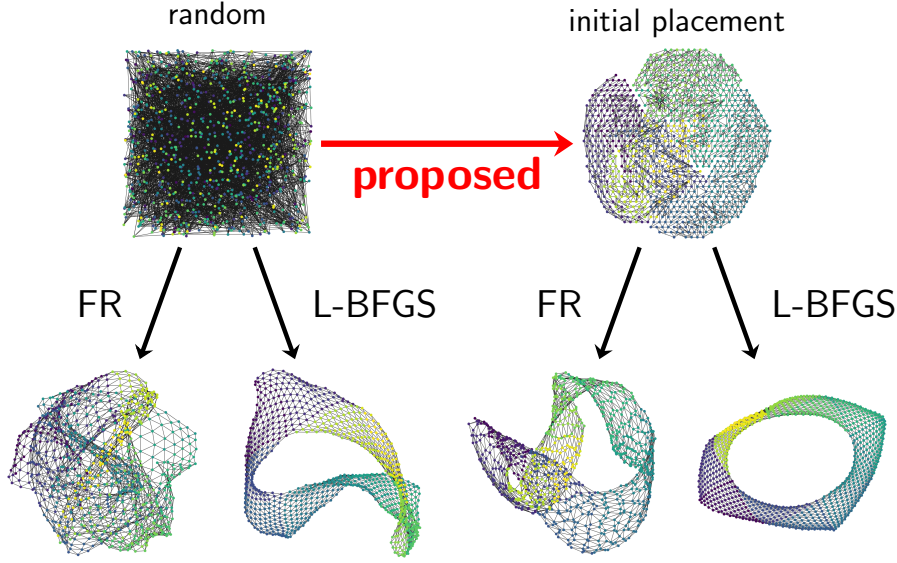


Figure 1: Comparison of the algorithms for the jagmesh1.

method, has been reported to produce high-quality layouts for several force models [20], including the FR force model and Kamada–Kawai (KK) model [22]. Although effective, both approaches require many computationally expensive iterations. When the optimization is terminated early, the resulting layouts may contain twists, including folded or tangled structures that reduce readability, as shown in Fig. 1 [6, 31].

One possible approach to mitigating the issue is to improve the initial placement before refinement. Since FR and L-BFGS algorithms involve relatively expensive iterations, it is often more efficient to first move the layout toward a reasonably good configuration using inexpensive approximate updates, and then apply full-cost refinement methods only after the layout becomes sufficiently close to equilibrium. In other words, this pre-processing substitutes for part of the refinement while reducing the overall optimization difficulty.

A pre-processing step based on Simulated Annealing (SA) has been shown to improve the final visualization quality when combined with the FR algorithm [14]. However, the existing method assumes circular initial layouts and employs a relatively heuristic objective function, insufficiently grounded in the underlying force model. In addition, the method mainly targets unweighted, small-scale, and structurally simple graphs, limiting its applicability to more general graph drawing settings.

In this paper, we propose a new initial placement to quickly obtain the equilibrium layout of the force models, especially the FR force model. We provide an initial placement with fewer twists than random placement within a short time, accelerating the subsequent optimization process. We can use both FR and L-BFGS algorithms to obtain the final placement. This work extends the applicability of the initial placement idea to larger-scale, weighted, and complicated structured graphs. To achieve this, we optimize the position of vertices one by one with the coordinate Newton direction, leveraging the inherent structure and the sparsity of graphs. We also demonstrate its effectiveness through various experiments.

The remainder of the paper is organized as follows.

- In Sec. 2, we provide the technical definitions of the problem.
- In Sec. 3, we review some related work.
- In Sec. 4, we present our initial placement algorithm.

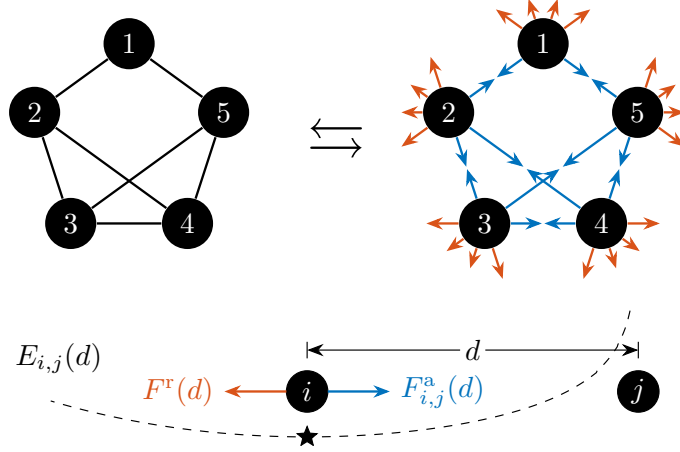


Figure 2: In the model, forces act on every pair of vertices. Forces $F_{i,j}^a(d)$ and $F^r(d)$ work between vertices i and j . The equilibrium of them is achieved at $d = k/\sqrt[3]{a_{i,j}}$, which equals k when $a_{i,j} = 1$.

- In Sec. 5, we report experimental comparisons.
- In Sec. 6, we discuss our approach and its potential applications.
- In Sec. 7, we conclude the paper and discuss future work.

2 Preliminaries

In this study, we adopt an energy-based optimization approach for graph drawing. While Fruchterman and Reingold [11] originally proposed the force-directed FR algorithm based on a physical particle system simulation, energy-based methods achieve the same goal by directly minimizing an energy function Φ . These two perspectives are fundamentally equivalent because a local minimum of the energy function $\Phi(X)$ yields an equilibrium position since $\nabla \Phi(X)$ corresponds to the forces. In this sense, the force-based and energy-based perspectives are equivalent as both capture equilibrium, illustrated in Fig. 2.

Let us formally define the energy-minimization problem. Let $G = (V, E)$ be an undirected graph with vertex set $V = \{1, \dots, n\}$ and edge set E . Each edge $\{i, j\} \in E$ has positive weight $a_{i,j} = a_{j,i} \in \mathbb{R}$. For convenience, we set $a_{i,j} = 0$ for $\{i, j\} \notin E$. In this problem, the force model assumes forces between vertices. For vertices i and j with distance $d > 0$, an attractive force $F_{i,j}^a(d)$ and a repulsive force $F^r(d)$ are defined as

$$F_{i,j}^a(d) := \frac{a_{i,j}d^2}{k}, \quad F^r(d) := -\frac{k^2}{d},$$

where $k > 0$ is a constant parameter, often set to $1/\sqrt{n}$ [11]. The scalar potentials of these forces [20] are given by

$$\begin{aligned} \Phi_{i,j}^a(d) &:= \int_0^d F_{i,j}^a(r) dr = \frac{a_{i,j}d^3}{3k}, & \Phi^r(d) &:= \int_1^d F^r(r) dr = -k^2 \log d, \\ \Phi_{i,j}(d) &:= \Phi_{i,j}^a(d) + \Phi^r(d). \end{aligned}$$

For simplicity, we define $\Phi_{i,j}(0) = \infty$.¹ Let $\|\cdot\|$ denote the Euclidean norm in $\mathbb{R}^2$. Then,

¹We can also use $-k^2 \log(d + \epsilon^r)$ for $\Phi^r(d)$ to prevent divergence, where ϵ^r is constant.

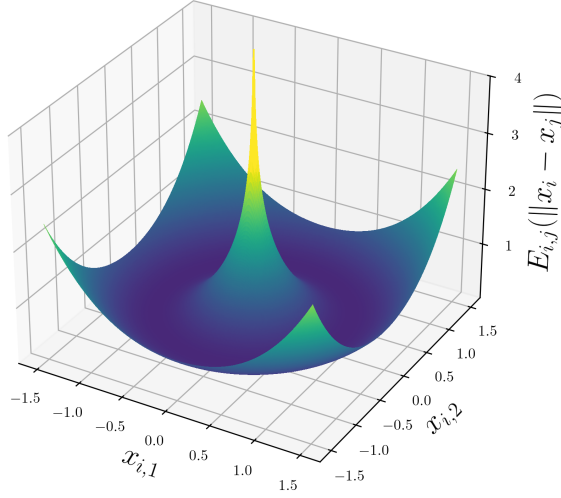


Figure 3: The energy function $\Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|)$ for $x_i = (x_{i,1}, x_{i,2})$, $x_j = (0, 0)$, $a_{i,j} = 1$, and $k = 1$.

the problem is to minimize the energy with $X := (x_1, \dots, x_n) \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}$:

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \Phi(X) := \sum_{i < j} \Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|). \quad (1)$$

While the energy function $\Phi_{i,j}(d)$ is convex and minimized when $d = k/\sqrt[3]{a_{i,j}}$ for a positive $a_{i,j}$, a function $x_i \mapsto \Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|)$ is non-convex for a fixed x_j . Additionally, $\Phi_{i,j}$ is not Lipschitz continuous near $d = 0$, as illustrated in Fig. 3. These properties highlight the difficulty of the optimization problem.

3 Related Work

We next summarize the existing literature relevant to our work.

3.1 Optimization Approach

Optimization-based methods for graph drawing have been actively investigated. Representative approaches include GPU acceleration [13], machine learning techniques [29], multi-objective formulations [1], and stochastic gradient descent [35]. Among these, our attention is on the underlying optimization algorithms itself.

Problem (1) can be interpreted as a continuous optimization problem. Let Φ_i denote the contribution of vertex x_i to the objective function Φ , defined by

$$\Phi_i(x_i) := \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|).$$

Here, $\Phi_{i,j}(\cdot) = \Phi_{j,i}(\cdot)$ holds for all $i, j \in V$. The i -th column of the gradient $\nabla \Phi(X) \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}$ is given by

$$(\nabla \Phi(X))_i := \nabla \Phi_i(x_i) = \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) (x_i - x_j)$$

$$= \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) (x_i - x_j).$$

Since both the objective value and gradient are explicitly available, a variety of gradient-based optimization methods can be applied to problem (1). The classical FR algorithm may be interpreted as a steepest-descent-type method in which the step size is controlled by a cooling schedule. Indeed, $(\nabla \Phi(X))_i$ corresponds to the force acting on vertex i . The L-BFGS algorithm, a renowned and widely used optimization method, is another first-order gradient-based method that has been shown to consistently outperform the original FR algorithm in speed and layout quality [20]. A common choice for the initial solution is a random placement of nodes within the bounding box $\{(x_i^{(1)}, x_i^{(2)}) \mid 0 \leq x_i^{(1)} \leq 1, 0 \leq x_i^{(2)} \leq 1\}$ [32].

However, when the input is highly twisted or otherwise ill-conditioned, both FR algorithm and the L-BFGS algorithm can suffer from large per-iteration costs: each iteration operates on the full set of coordinates, which limits its ability to untangle local geometric defects. Thus, to address these issues, we need an alternative optimization approach that differs from both the FR algorithm and the L-BFGS algorithm. As such an approach, this study proposes stochastic coordinate descent with coordinate Newton directions, a second-order optimization method used as preprocessing for first-order gradient-based methods.

3.2 Initial Placement Approach

A preprocessing step with Simulated Annealing (SA) is known to be effective [14] since SA can avoid getting stuck in local optima and leads to better visualization, combined with the FR algorithm. Let

$$Q^{\text{circle}} := \{(\cos(2\pi k/n), \sin(2\pi k/n)) \mid 1 \leq k \leq n\}$$

be the points on a unit circle in $\mathbb{R}^2$. For an unweighted graph G , let E_2 be a set of vertex pairs with a shortest path distance equal to 2. Let $\angle(a, b)$ denote the angle between the lines from the origin to the points a and b , measured in the interval $(-\pi, \pi]$. This study [14] defines the problem for the preprocessing of graph drawing as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} & \underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} && \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E \cup E_2} |\angle(x_i, x_j)|, \\ & \text{subject to} && x_i \in Q^{\text{circle}} \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i \leq n, \\ & && x_i \neq x_j \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i < j \leq n. \end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

The problem (2) is a discrete optimization problem where the placement is limited to Q^{circle} and uses angles, not the function Φ in the problem (1). This study obtains a faster and better visualization by setting the result of Simulated Annealing (SA) for the problem (2) as an initial placement for the FR algorithm.

Still, the following limitations remain:

- The target graphs are restricted to unweighted ones.
- The layout is confined to a simple circle, which could be ineffective for complex structured graphs.
- The neighborhood in the SA is the random swapping of two vertices, making the optimization process inefficient for large-scale graphs.
- $|E_2|$ could be $\Theta(|V|^2)$, unable to leverage the sparsity of graphs if it exists.

We address these limitations, and our study is an extension of this work.

143 4 Proposed Algorithm

144 With the prior studies in Sec. 3.1, this section proposes Algorithm 1, a new initial place-
 145 ment algorithm for the problem (1). The algorithm solves a discrete optimization problem
 146 with stochastic coordinate descent to find an initial placement with fewer twists. This
 147 algorithm leverages the properties of the objective function to determine the initial lay-
 148 out quickly. By combining it with optimization methods like the L-BFGS algorithm, it
 149 enhances the overall convergence speed of graph drawing through optimization.

150 4.1 Newton Direction and Coordinate Newton Direction

151 Consider a strictly convex function $g: \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ at x_0 . The Newton direction $d =$
 152 $-\nabla^2 g(x_0)^{-1} \nabla g(x_0)$ is an optimal direction for the second order approximation of g :

$$g(x_0) + \nabla g(x_0)^\top (x - x_0) + \frac{1}{2} (x - x_0)^\top \nabla^2 g(x_0) (x - x_0).$$

153 $x = x_0 + d$ is the minimizer of this approximation. Note that the Hessian matrix $\nabla^2 g(x_0)$
 154 is positive definite since g is strictly convex. Although the Newton direction is essential in
 155 various iterative methods, it requires the computation of the inverse Hessian $\nabla^2 g(x_0)^{-1} \in$
 156 $\mathbb{R}^{n \times n}$, posing a high computational cost for large-scale problems.

157 Still, we can leverage the concept of the Newton direction in a different manner, the
 158 coordinate Newton direction. Instead of computing the inverse Hessian $\nabla^2 g(x_0)^{-1}$ in
 159 the entire variable space $\mathbb{R}^n$, we restrict the variable x to its coordinate block x_i with
 160 fewer dimensions, and compute $\nabla^2 g_i(x_i)^{-1} \nabla g_i(x_i)$ where g_i is a restricted function of g
 161 to x_i . Since the coordinate Newton direction computation is much cheaper than that of
 162 the Newton direction, we can repeat this procedure many times. In general, this idea is
 163 known as stochastic coordinate descent [34] or Randomized Subspace Newton [15] in a
 164 broader context.

165 In particular, this coordinate Newton direction has an apparent natural affinity to the
 166 problem (1). We can compute the coordinate Newton direction by taking the position
 167 x_i of the vertex i as the coordinate block. Although directly applying this idea to the
 168 problem (1) is challenging, as we will discuss in Sec. 6.2, we leverage this coordinate
 169 Newton direction to propose our algorithm.

170 4.2 Discrete Optimization Problem for Initial Placement

171 Even at the expense of accuracy, obtaining an approximate solution quickly is crucial for
 172 the initial placement. To obtain it, we simplify the problem (1) into a more manageable
 173 and well-behaved discrete optimization problem:

$$\begin{aligned} & \underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} && \Phi^a(X) := \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k}, \\ & \text{subject to} && x_i \in Q^{\text{hex}} \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i \leq n, \\ & && x_i \neq x_j \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i < j \leq n, \end{aligned} \tag{3}$$

174 where

$$Q^{\text{hex}} := \left\{ \left(q + \frac{1}{2}r, \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}r \right) \mid q \in \mathbb{Z}, r \in \mathbb{Z} \right\}. \tag{4}$$

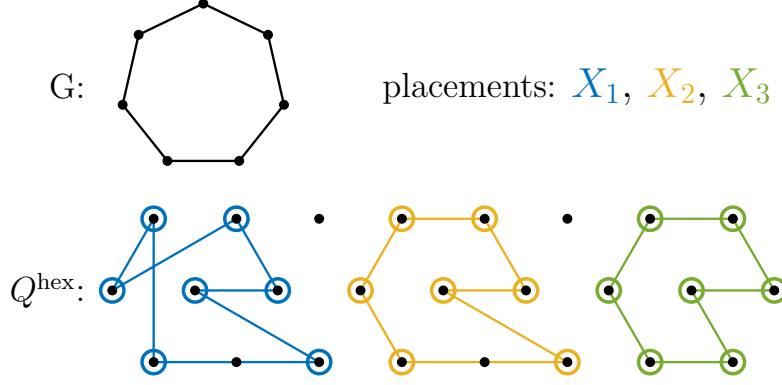


Figure 4: Concept of Q . The assignment from V to a discrete point placement Q , especially a hexagonal lattice Q^{hex} . Apparently, among the three placements, the right one is the best placement for the problem (3).

175 First, the problem (1) is equivalent to the following:

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k} - \sum_{i < j} k^2 \log \|x_i - x_j\|.$$

176 This formulation separates the $\mathcal{O}(|E|)$ terms from $\Phi_{i,j}^a$ and the $\mathcal{O}(|V|^2)$ terms from Φ^r .

177 Here, following previous research mentioned in Sec. 3.2, we fix the possible positions x_i
 178 of each vertex i to a discrete set of points Q , where $|Q| \geq |V|$. It means that we consider
 179 the following:

$$\begin{aligned} & \underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k} - \sum_{i < j} k^2 \log \|x_i - x_j\|, \\ & \text{subject to} \quad x_i \in Q \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i \leq n, \\ & \quad \quad \quad x_i \neq x_j \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i < j \leq n. \end{aligned}$$

180 The goal is to simplify the objective function and choose Q appropriately to derive a
 181 well-simplified problem.

182 Due to the sparsity of many practical graphs, $|E| \ll |V|^2$ holds. To leverage this
 183 sparsity for simplification, we want to drop the second term that arises from the repulsive
 184 energy Φ^r :

$$- \sum_{i < j} k^2 \log \|x_i - x_j\|.$$

185 We impose a condition on Q such that $\|q_i - q_j\| \geq \epsilon$ for all $q_i, q_j \in Q$ with $q_i \neq q_j$. In
 186 this case, the term above is negligible. Since $\Phi^r(d) = -k^2 \log d$ is a convex function such
 187 that it decreases monotonically concerning d , for sufficiently large d , the value of $-k^2 \log d$
 188 does not vary excessively. For too small d , we can prevent the divergence of the energy
 189 function by setting ϵ . Thus, under this condition, we drop the second term and derive the
 190 problem as:

$$\begin{aligned} & \underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k}, \\ & \text{subject to} \quad x_i \in Q \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i \leq n, \end{aligned}$$

$$x_i \neq x_j \quad \text{for } 1 \leq i < j \leq n.$$

191 This means that we skip to consider the $\mathcal{O}(|V|^2)$ pairs (all pairs of $\{i, j\}$ with $1 \leq i < j \leq n$)
 192 by fixing the possible point placement in advance, reducing the computational complexity
 193 to $\mathcal{O}(|E|)$ and thus offering significant speedup. See Fig. 4 for a visual explanation.

194 We can consider various placements for the Q , including Q^{circle} [14]. In this study, we
 195 adopt a hexagonal lattice Q^{hex} [23, 27] defined by Eq. (4) (see Fig. 4). When minimizing
 196 the objective function that arises from the attractive energy Φ^a , it is advantageous for the
 197 points to cluster as closely as possible. In this context, the hexagonal lattice is known
 198 for its densest packing structure in space with the least distance ϵ between points [5] and
 199 offers computational simplicity. Thus, Q^{hex} is a suitable choice, and we have derived the
 200 problem (3).

201 4.3 Newton Direction for Discrete Optimization

202 Next, we solve the discrete optimization problem (3). Although this problem is challenging
 203 to solve just using simple methods, the coordinate Newton direction of a randomly selected
 204 vertex i provides significant insights as mentioned in Sec. 4.1. Therefore, we can offer a
 205 high-quality solution to the problem. Let the restricted objective function $\Phi_i^a(x_i)$ be

$$\Phi_i^a(x_i) := \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k}.$$

206 Its gradient and Hessian matrix are

$$\begin{aligned} \nabla \Phi_i^a(x_i) &= \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} (x_i - x_j), \\ \nabla^2 \Phi_i^a(x_i) &= \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} + \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \frac{a_{i,j}}{k \|x_i - x_j\|} (x_i - x_j)(x_i - x_j)^\top. \end{aligned}$$

207 This means Φ_i^a is strictly convex, assuring the Hessian matrix $\nabla^2 \Phi_i^a(x_i)$ is positive definite.
 208 This is a large difference from the functions $\Phi(X)$ in the problem (1) and $\Phi^a(X)$ in the
 209 problem (3), which are non-convex.

210 The ordinary updated rule with the coordinate Newton direction is

$$x_i^{\text{new}} \leftarrow x_i - \nabla^2 \Phi_i^a(x_i)^{-1} \nabla \Phi_i^a(x_i).$$

211 x_i^{new} may not be in the hexagonal lattice Q^{hex} in the problem (3). Thus, we project this
 212 x_i^{new} onto the nearest point in Q^{hex} . We also empirically found that adding a random
 213 noise vector to the Newton direction is effective for the optimization process, a strategy
 214 similar to the SA in Sec. 3.2. This randomness can help to escape from local minima
 215 and to explore the solution space more effectively. In conclusion, the updated rule for the
 216 vertex i is

$$x_i^{\text{new}} \leftarrow \text{round}(x_i - \nabla^2 \Phi_i^a(x_i)^{-1} \nabla \Phi_i^a(x_i) + t \cdot r),$$

217 where $\text{round}(\hat{x})$ denotes the operation assigning $\hat{x}$ to the nearest point in the hexagonal
 218 lattice Q^{hex} , r is a random vector with a unit norm, and the parameter t is gradually
 219 decreased as the iterations proceed and is designed to converge to zero eventually.

220 If there is a vertex j such that $x_j = x_i^{\text{new}}$, we swap the positions x_i and x_j to satisfy
 221 the condition $x_i \neq x_j$. Otherwise, we just update x_i to x_i^{new} . Refer to Fig. 5 for a visual
 222 explanation. Repeating this procedure yields an approximate solution to the problem (3).

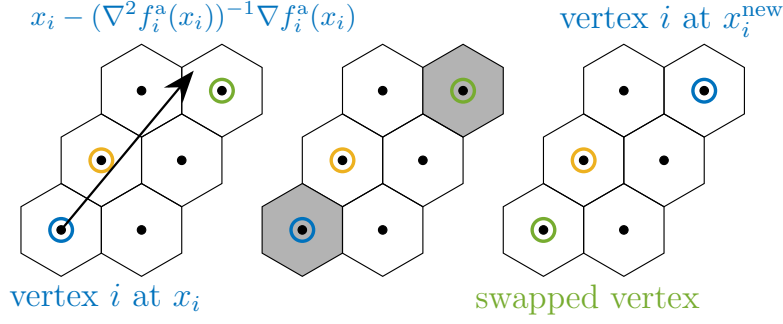


Figure 5: One iteration of the proposed algorithm. Step 1. Compute the coordinate Newton direction (blue). Step 2. Decide x_i^{new} by rounding the direction and adding a random vector. Step 3. Move the vertex and swap the vertices if necessary (swap blue and green vertices).

4.4 Optimal Scaling

The obtained solution could be too small or too large since we did not care about the scale ϵ . Thus, as the final step, we rescale the placement to improve it.

Let us formulate the optimization problem for the scaling factor $s > 0$. For an initial placement $X = (x_1, \dots, x_n)$, we scale it as $x_i \leftarrow s x_i$ for all i . The problem of minimizing $\Phi(X)$ through scaling is equivalent to minimizing $\phi(s)$ defined by

$$\begin{aligned}\phi(s) &:= \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j}(s\|x_i - x_j\|)^3}{3k} - k^2 \sum_{i < j} \log(s\|x_i - x_j\|), \\ \phi'(s) &= \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} \frac{a_{i,j}\|x_i - x_j\|^3}{k} s^2 - \frac{k^2 n(n-1)}{2s}.\end{aligned}$$

The function $\phi(s)$ is convex, and the optimal scaling factor s^* satisfies $\phi'(s^*) = 0$, which yields

$$s^* = \left(\frac{k^3 n(n-1)}{2 \sum_{\{i,j\} \in E} a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3} \right)^{1/3}. \quad (5)$$

This value can be computed in $\mathcal{O}(|E|)$ complexity, enabling us to obtain a better initial placement for the problem (1).

Notably, the optimal solution to the problem (3) is invariant under scaling. Thus, we do not have to care about the scale factor for the hexagonal lattice Q^{hex} as far as we scale the obtained placement by s^* .

4.5 Alternative Approach

To end this section, we explain an alternative approach to the problem (3). We can also solve the problem by updating all vertices simultaneously, not one by one. It means moving all the points $\{x_i\}_{i \in V}$ to arbitrary positions and then assigning all these $|V|$ points to the nearest points on Q^{hex} . The optimal assignment for $\{x_i\}_{i \in V}$ to Q^{hex} is computable by a Hungarian algorithm in $\mathcal{O}(|V|^3)$ time or some heuristic.

Algorithm 1: Proposed algorithm for the initial placement

Input: Graph $G = (V, E)$, Weight $(a_{i,j})_{\{i,j\} \in E}$, Parameters $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{CN}} \in \mathbb{N}$, and $t_0 > 0$
Output: Initial placement $X = (x_1, \dots, x_n)$

```

1  $t \leftarrow t_0$ ;
2 Sample  $x_i \in Q^{\text{hex}}$  for all  $i \in V$  without replacement;
3 for  $m \leftarrow 0$  to  $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{CN}}$  do
4   Select vertex  $i \in V$  randomly;
5   Draw  $r \in \mathbb{R}^2$  randomly from a unit circle;
6    $x_i^{\text{new}} \leftarrow \text{round}(x_i - \nabla^2 \Phi_i^{\text{a}}(x_i)^{-1} \nabla \Phi_i^{\text{a}}(x_i) + t \cdot r)$ ;
7   if  $\exists j \in V$  such that  $x_j = x_i^{\text{new}}$  then
8      $x_j \leftarrow x_i$ ;
9    $x_i \leftarrow x_i^{\text{new}}$ ;
10   $t \leftarrow t - t_0 / N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{CN}}$ ;
11  $x_i \leftarrow s^* x_i$  for all  $i \in V$  with  $s^*$  given by Eq. (5);
12 return  $X$ 

```

4.6 Application to Other Force Models

We briefly discuss and explore the potential applicability of stochastic coordinate descent to a broader range of problems. Although we utilized the coordinate Newton direction only for the optimization problem (1), we can see that its application is not necessarily limited to the FR force model, the problem (1).

Recall that Our optimization problem (1) can be rewritten as

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \Phi_{\text{FR}}(X) = \sum_{(i,j) \in E} \frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|^3}{3k} - \sum_{\substack{(i,j) \in V^2 \\ i \neq j}} k^2 \log(\epsilon^r + \|x_i - x_j\|).$$

Similar objective functions arise from other force models, such as ... are as follows:

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \Phi_{\text{HC}}(X) = \sum_{(i,j) \in E} \frac{k_1 (\|x_i - x_j\| - a_{ij})^2}{2} + \sum_{\substack{(i,j) \in V^2 \\ i \neq j}} \frac{k_2}{\|x_i - x_j\| + \epsilon^r}$$

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \Phi_{\text{Eades}}(X) = \sum_{(i,j) \in E} k_1 \|x_i - x_j\| \left(\log \frac{\|x_i - x_j\|}{a_{ij}} - 1 \right) + \sum_{\substack{(i,j) \in V^2 \\ i \neq j}} \frac{k_2}{\|x_i - x_j\| + \epsilon^r}$$

Clearly, these objective functions are also non-convex and have a similar structure to $\Phi_{\text{FR}}(X)$, which consists of a sum of terms associated with edges and a sum of terms associated with all pairs of vertices.

The coordinate Newton direction can be computed for each vertex in these models as well, and the stochastic coordinate descent approach can be applied to optimize the layout efficiently.

なお、より広い枠組みとして、stochastic coordinate descent は、グラフから生じる目的関数に対して、各頂点の位置を座標ブロックとして取ることで適用できます [34]。それ故に KK model に対しても同様のアプローチが可能であると考えられます。しかし、提案手

259 法をそのまま apply することは難しいと考えています。KK model の目的関数は、以下の通
260 りです。

$$\underset{X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}}{\text{minimize}} \quad \Phi_{\text{KK}}(X) := \sum_{\substack{(i,j) \in V^2 \\ i \neq j}} \frac{(\|x_i - x_j\| - l_{ij})^2}{2l_{ij}^2}$$

261 実際、これは先ほどまでにあげた目的関数と同様の構造を持っていますが、KK model の目
262 的関数は、すべての頂点ペアに対して項が存在するため、計算コストが高くなります。この
263 ような場合は、恐らく SGD を用いた方が良いです。[35]

264 5 Numerical Experiment

265 In this section, we evaluate the proposed algorithm with various numerical experiments.
266 We also confirm that the proposed algorithm efficiently provides a good initial placement
267 even for larger weighted graphs.

268 5.1 Experimental Setup

269 We conducted all numerical experiments in this section using C ++17 compiled by GCC
270 10.5.0 on a laptop computer powered by Intel(R) Core(TM) i7-10510U CPU with 16 GB
271 RAM.

272 For a fair comparison, we implemented the FR algorithm in C ++ based on NetworkX
273 version 3.3 [16], SciPy 1.14.1 [32], and utilized the C ++ L-BFGS [26, 28] library for the
274 L-BFGS algorithm. We also referred to the open-source code of the hexagonal grid [27]
275 and Graphviz version 2.43.0 [10].

276 We used the 3×2 algorithms. As an initial placement, we used

- 277 • random initialization (no prefix),
- 278 • the SA initialization obtained by Simulated Annealing (SA-) [14],
- 279 • the proposed initialization obtained with coordinate Newton direction (CN-).

280 As an algorithm to solve the problem (1), we used

- 281 • FR algorithm (FR),
- 282 • L-BFGS algorithm (L-BFGS).

283 The key remark is that we slightly modified the FR algorithm so that it automatically
284 adjust the stepsize. This is to isolate the effect of the proposed initialization from the
285 effect of the stepsize. This is just done by a simple backtracking line search at the first
286 iteration.

287 As parameters, we used initial temperature $t_0 = 1.5$ and the number of iterations
288 $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{CN}} = 2|V|^3/|E|$ for Algorithm 1, and we also set the total number of iterations of
289 Simulated Annealing (SA) in Sec. 3.2 to the same value. Since the Algorithm 1 requires a
290 computational time proportional to the degree of the selected vertex in each iteration, the
291 expected computational time per iteration is $\mathcal{O}(|E|/|V|)$. Consequently, we can roughly
292 estimate that the total computational time of the proposed algorithm is $\mathcal{O}(|V|^2)$, equivalent
293 to a few iterations of the FR or L-BFGS algorithms. All the codes are available at
294 GitHub [19].

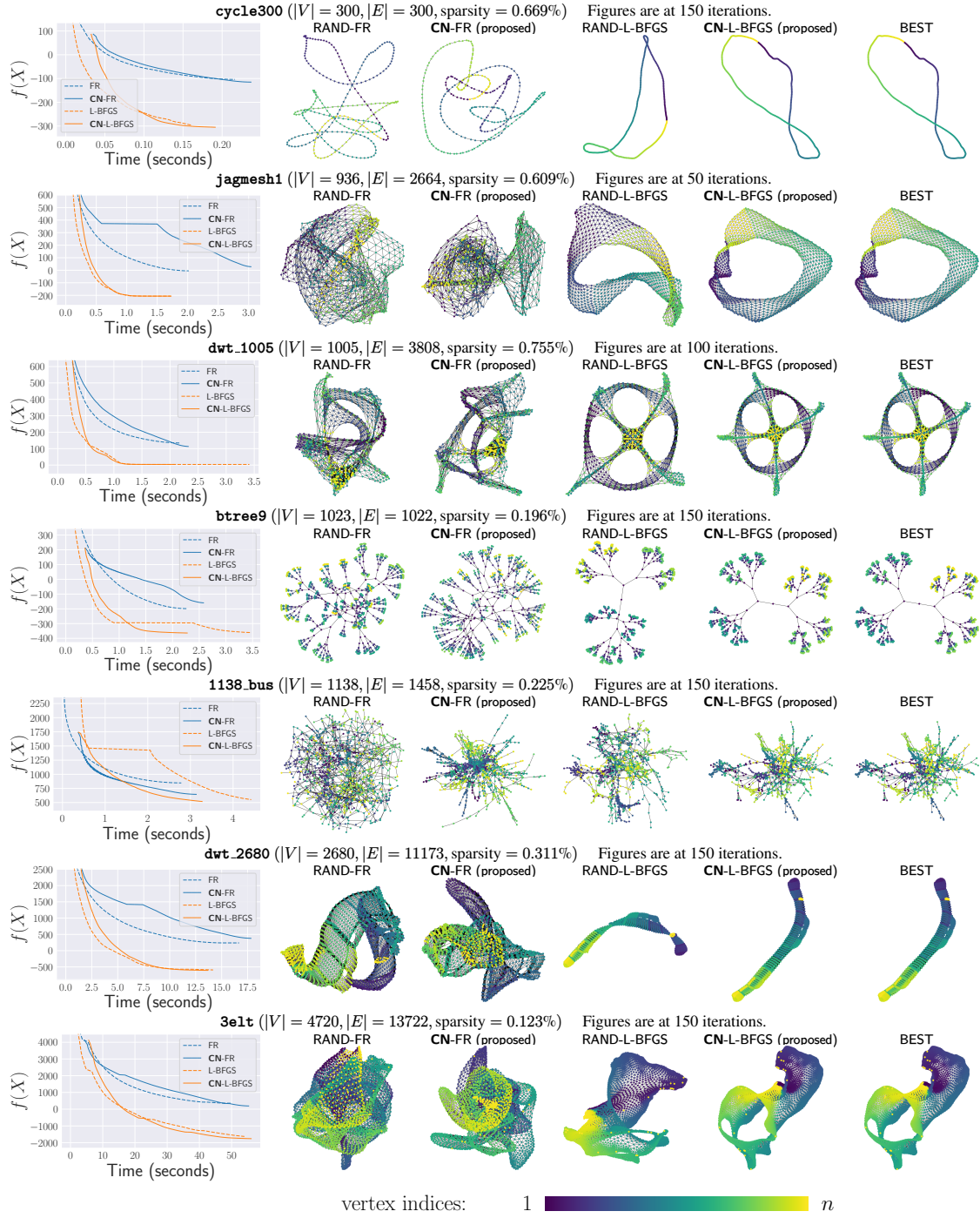


Figure 6: Experimental results. Our proposed method CN, Coordinate Newton, yields improved results for both FR and L-BFGS. The “BEST” reports the performance of CN-L-BFGS within at most 500 iterations. The color of vertices represents their indices.

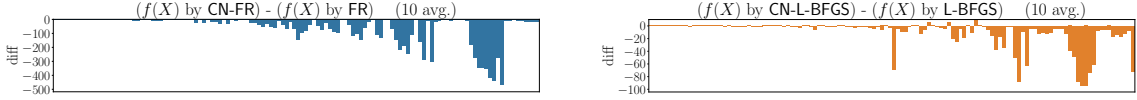


Figure 7: Comparison of the proposed initialization (CN) with random initialization (no prefix). In almost all cases, the difference is negative, meaning the proposed algorithm performed faster and better than random initialization.

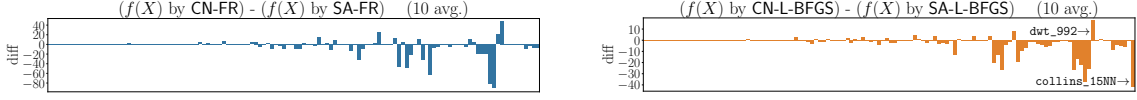


Figure 8: Comparison of the proposed initialization (CN) with SA initialization (SA) in Ref. [14]. In most cases, the proposed algorithm performed better than the SA initialization.

295 5.2 Plots and Visualizations

296 We first show the plots and visualizations of the algorithms in Fig. 6. The experiment
 297 details are as follows. We fixed the maximum number of iterations of the FR and L-BFGS
 298 algorithms as $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}} = N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{L-BFGS}} = 200$. We tested with 7 graphs: `cycle300`, `jagmesh1`,
 299 `dwt_1005`, `btree9`, `1138_bus`, `dwt_2680`, and `3elt`. Here `cycle300` is a cycle graph with
 300 300 vertices, and `btree9` is a perfect binary tree with $2^{9+1} - 1 = 1023$ vertices. Other
 301 graphs are from Sparse Matrix Collection [8], and these choices are based on Ref. [35].

302 In Fig. 6, the plots on the left illustrate the objective function values $\Phi(X)$, the average
 303 of the ten trials for each algorithm. The graphs on the right are at the iteration in which
 304 the most significant difference appeared among $\{50, 100, 150\}$ -th iterations (or at the last
 305 iteration if it ended earlier). The vertices in the graphs are colored according to vertex
 306 indices.

307 The observations and implications of Fig. 6 are as follows. First, the plots with solid
 308 lines for CN generally demonstrate superior performance to those with dashed lines for
 309 non-CN. These results validate the efficacy of the proposed method. Secondly, the initial
 310 values of $\Phi(X)$ with CN-FR are significantly smaller than those with FR, suggesting that
 311 the proposed method provides a good initial placement. Thirdly, the visualization results
 312 also support the effectiveness of the proposed initial placement. In most cases, placements
 313 obtained with CN better reflect the nearly optimal arrangement shown in the “BEST”.

314 As a side note, regardless of CN or non-CN, the algorithms with L-BFGS consistently
 315 outperform those with FR. This finding is consistent with prior research [20] and providing
 316 solid evidence for the effectiveness of L-BFGS.

317 We provide more visualization results in appendix, including more large graphs. [3]

318 5.3 Results for Other Force Models

319 先述の通り、提案手法は他の force model にも適用可能である。(この結果は本文に載せるべきか?)
 320

321 6 Discussion

322 6.1 Application to ???

323 簡潔に、この手法は multilevel approach と組み合わせることができることを説明する。

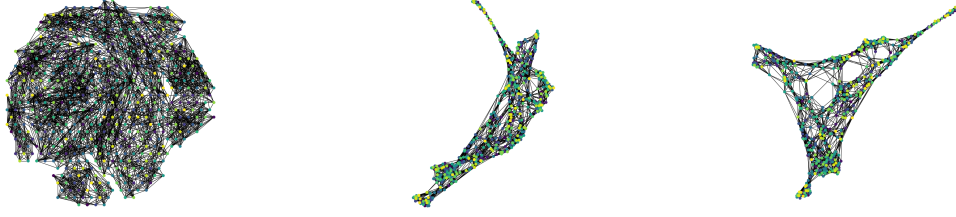


Figure 9: Spectro_10NN, where the proposed algorithm performed worse than random initialization. Left: Initial placement by CN. Middle and Right: 50th and 200th iteration of CN-L-BFGS.



Figure 10: An example of a case where $a_{i,j} \notin \{0,1\}$. Left: the result of CN, which is better as the vertices are separated by colors. Right: the result of SA, which is worse as there is no separation.

Multilevel approaches such as `sfdp` [21] in Graphviz are important prior work for obtaining the equilibrium layout of the force model, i.e., solving the problem (1). These methods use hierarchical coarsening and refinement to achieve efficient layout computation for large graphs. Our work is complementary to such multilevel methods. Optimization techniques such as L-BFGS can be directly applied to the refinement stages within multilevel pipelines. Since the approaches proposed in this study can be incorporated into multilevel frameworks with appropriate modifications, our primary objective is to quantify and enhance the refinement procedure itself. Therefore, we deliberately exclude coarsening and other approximation steps from the present analysis. For further details on multilevel approaches, the reader is referred to [2, 17, 33].

超大規模なグラフに対して描画を考えると、先ほどは hexagonal lattice を用いて配置していたが、これは必ずしも hexagonal lattice である必要はなく、頂点の位置の候補となる点集合が互いに十分な距離離れていれば、十分にこの手法は機能すると考えている。

The FR model is usually used for dynamic graph layouts like animation and interaction. Also, the FR model is sometimes used for very large graphs because simulation-based algorithms for the FR model can be more scalable than Newton-like algorithms for the KK model. One plausible direction for the authors might be to combine the proposed algorithm with a scalable simulation-based algorithm for the FR model and to apply it to very large graphs.

6.2 Rationale for the Discretization Approach

This section explains why we did not apply the coordinate Newton direction technique directly to the original problem (1), but instead first transformed it into the discrete optimization problem (3). At first sight, one might expect that applying the coordinate Newton method directly to (1) would be more natural and possibly more efficient, since it avoids the detour through discretization. However, as we shall see, this approach suffers from intrinsic difficulties that undermine its effectiveness. By contrast, our discretization-based formulation allows us to circumvent these difficulties while still exploiting the ad-

351 vantages of the coordinate Newton direction. This not only justifies our methodological
 352 choice but also provides a foundation for exploring further optimization strategies built
 353 upon this framework. In what follows, we clarify the limitations of the direct approach
 354 and explain how our method addresses them.

355 6.2.1 Possible Alternatives

356 One natural idea for solving problem (1) is to apply existing optimization algorithms such
 357 as Stochastic Gradient Descent (SGD) or Stochastic Coordinate Descent.

358 Applying SGD to graph drawing, particularly to the Kamada – Kawai (KK) lay-
 359 out [22], has been a notable direction [1, 35]. The KK model determines the layout by
 360 minimizing a stress-like energy $\Phi_{i,j}^{\text{KK}}$ defined for all vertex pairs. SGD corresponds to
 361 randomly selecting an edge i, j and updating x_i and x_j using the gradient of $\Phi_{i,j}^{\text{KK}}$. This
 362 stochastic treatment reduces per-iteration complexity while retaining structural informa-
 363 tion, as $\Phi_{i,j}^{\text{KK}}$ is defined in terms of graph distance.

364 In contrast, applying SGD directly to the FR force model is ineffective. When $a_{i,j} = 0$,
 365 the energy term reduces to $\Phi_{i,j} = -k^2 \log d$, which depends only on Euclidean distance
 366 and ignores the graph structure. Consequently, gradients from a single sampled pair often
 367 fail to provide meaningful information for optimization.

368 Another approach is to use Stochastic Coordinate Descent, which resembles Random-
 369 ized Subspace Newton methods [4, 12, 15, 18, 25]. For each vertex i , define the local
 370 energy

$$\Phi_i(x_i) := \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|), \quad (6)$$

371 whose gradient (the net force on i) and Hessian are

$$\begin{aligned} \nabla \Phi_i(x_i) &= \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) (x_i - x_j), \\ \nabla^2 \Phi_i(x_i) &= \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} + \\ &\quad \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{a_{i,j}}{k \|x_i - x_j\|} + \frac{2k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^4} \right) (x_i - x_j)(x_i - x_j)^\top. \end{aligned}$$

372 A direct SCD scheme randomly selects a vertex i , applies Newton’ s method (or a reg-
 373 ularized variant) to Φ_i using the above gradient and Hessian, and updates x_i iteratively
 374 until convergence.

375 Although reasonable in spirit, this approach is also ineffective in practice. In the
 376 following, we illustrate the reasons for this failure with nontrivial examples.

377 6.2.2 Inaccuracy of Quadratic Approximation

378 One of the reasons it fails is the inaccuracy of the quadratic approximation; specifically, a
 379 particular issue arises when we restrict the optimization to a coordinate block.

380 Let G be a graph with $V = \{1, 2, 3, 4\}$ and $E = \{\{1, 2\}, \{2, 3\}, \{2, 4\}\}$. Set $k = 1/2$ and
 381 assign all positive edge weights $a_{i,j} = 1$ for every edge in E . The position of the vertices
 382 is

$$X = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & 0.9 & 0.9 \\ 0 & 0 & +0.1 & -0.1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

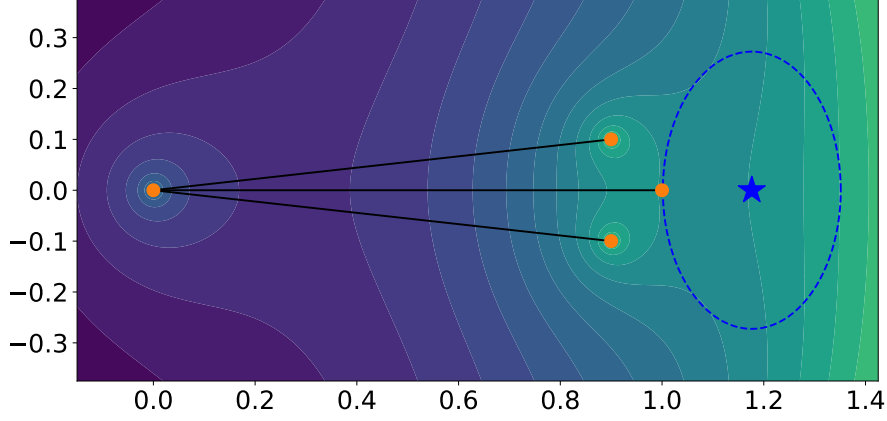


Figure 11: The inaccurate quadratic approximation. The blue star indicates the optimal solution for the quadratic approximation of $\Phi_1(x_1)$, but this differs significantly from the situation shown by the contour lines.

We show the contour of $\Phi_1(x_1)$ in Fig. 11. The key point of this example is that the Hessian

$$\nabla^2 \Phi_1(x_1) = \begin{pmatrix} 4.25 & 0 \\ 0 & 1.75 \end{pmatrix}$$

is positive definite and well-conditioned. Despite this favorable property of the Hessian, the coordinate Newton direction for x_1 results in a deviation from the global optimum. This issue arises from the inaccurate approximation of Φ_1 in the restricted block coordinates x_1 . The attractive force from vertex 2 and the repulsive forces from vertices 3 and 4 cancel each other out, leading to a highly inaccurate quadratic approximation. This deficiency cannot be entirely resolved by modifying Newton’s method, as it is an intrinsic and unavoidable limitation of the stochastic coordinate descent.

6.2.3 Ignorance of Other Vertices’ Movements

Another reason is the ignorance of other vertices’ movements when optimizing each vertex individually. When optimizing for a vertex i , the coordinate Newton direction treats all other vertices $V \setminus \{i\}$ as fixed.

Fig. 12 illustrates this issue. Consider a subset of vertices forming a mesh-like structure in G , where all vertices receive forces in the directions indicated by the blue arrows. In this situation, the FR and L-BFGS algorithms move all vertices simultaneously, allowing the simulation or optimization to proceed without issues. In contrast, the stochastic coordinate descent, as shown on the right side of the figure, brings stagnation. Here, all other vertices are considered fixed. Thus, optimizing the red vertex results in minimal movement, as its directly connected neighbors impede it. As a result, even after numerous iterations, little optimization is achieved. Thus, ignoring the movements of other vertices can be a significant limitation of the coordinate Newton method.

6.2.4 Rationale for Proposed Method

Our proposed method resolves issues in Secs. 6.2.2 and 6.2.3 by transforming the problem (1) into the problem (3) in Sec. 4.2, and optimizing Φ_i^a on Q^{hex} .

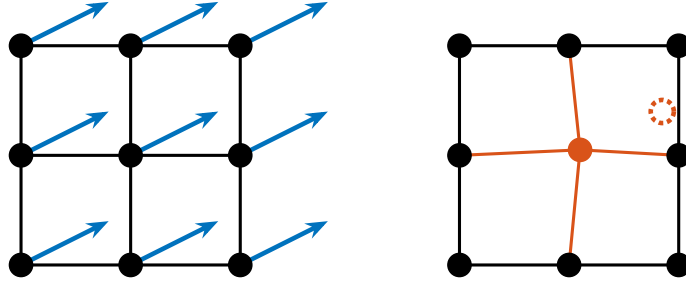


Figure 12: The blue arrows represent the acting forces in this situation. The center vertex exhibits only a minor shift in the coordinate Newton direction, while the red dashed vertex marks its ideal configuration.

Regarding the issue in Sec. 6.2.2, this transformation brings the convexity of the objective function as it treats the repulsive forces via a hexagonal lattice, making the quadratic approximation more accurate than the original problem. Regarding the issue in Sec. 6.2.3, the discrete point set Q ensures that the stepsize is larger than ϵ , as each point is always separated by at least ϵ . This large stepsize prevents stagnation in the optimization, and helps explore the solution space more efficiently. Furthermore, this transformation also brings the benefit of reducing computational complexity from $\mathcal{O}(|V|^2)$ to $\mathcal{O}(|E|)$.

Thus, converting the problem is crucial to provide a high-quality initial placement with the coordinate Newton direction. There may also be better transformation methods, and further exploration is warranted.

7 Conclusion

In this study, we proposed a new initial placement with the coordinate Newton direction for the FR force model, the problem (1). The obtained initial placements have fewer twists than the random initialization, leading to faster convergence and better visualization. Numerical experiments revealed that the proposed method is effective across various graphs, extending the applicability of the preprocessing step. The proposed method may advance the graph drawing, and we also hope it highlights the potential of the stochastic coordinate descent and its variants for addressing a broader range of graph-related optimization problems.

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A NetworkX Implementation

As supplementary information, this section explains how to solve the problem (1) and obtain the final placement. At the time of writing, NetworkX, an open-source library for graph analysis in Python, is set to release the L-BFGS-based method that we have implemented. Although this method does not use our proposed initial placement, we provide some implementation details as a reference in Sec. A.3.

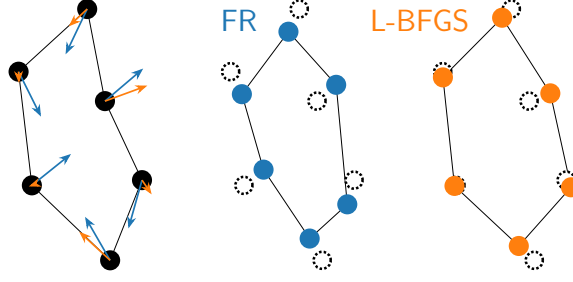


Figure 13: Comparison of the FR and L-BFGS algorithms. Blue arrows represent fixed stepsizes in FR, whereas orange arrows represent adaptive stepsizes determined by the approximate inverse Hessian

560 A.1 Fruchterman–Reingold Algorithm

Algorithm 2: Fruchterman–Reingold algorithm

Input: Graph $G = (V, E)$, Weights $(a_{i,j})_{\{i,j\} \in E}$, Parameters $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}} \in \mathbb{N}$, $t_0 > 0$,
and Initial placement $X = (x_1, \dots, x_n)$

Output: Final placement X

```

1  $t \leftarrow t_0$ ;
2 for  $m \leftarrow 1$  to  $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}}$  do
3   compute gradient  $\nabla \Phi_i(x_i)$  for all  $i \in V$ ;
561 4    $x_i^{\text{new}} \leftarrow x_i - t \frac{\nabla \Phi_i(x_i)}{\|\nabla \Phi_i(x_i)\|}$  for all  $i \in V$ ;
5    $x_i \leftarrow x_i^{\text{new}}$ ;
6    $t \leftarrow t - t_0 / N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}}$ ;
7   if convergence condition is satisfied then
8     break;
9 return  $X$ ;
```

562 The Fruchterman–Reingold algorithm [11] is the original and most standard approach
563 to obtain the equilibrium state of the force model. The pseudo-code is shown in Algo-
564 rithm 2, which is a variant of the gradient (steepest) descent method with the function Φ_i
565 in Eq. (6) [30].

566 Algorithm 2 is based on the original pseudo-code [11] and implementation in Net-
567 workX [16] with some omitted details. We typically draw the initial placement X from a
568 uniform distribution on $[0, 1]^{2 \times n}$. The parameter t denotes the temperature, which gov-
569 erns the stepsize along the steepest descent. As the temperature gradually decreases, the
570 algorithm converges to a particular placement, which is not necessarily a local optimum
571 of the problem (1).

572 A.2 L-BFGS Algorithm

573 Another approach is to leverage the L-BFGS algorithm [20]. Using only a few recent
574 gradient vectors, the L-BFGS algorithm approximates the inverse Hessian of the objective
575 function Φ [24]. L-BFGS is known to be very efficient for large-scale optimization problems.
576 We can apply the L-BFGS algorithm to the optimization problem (1) via flattening the
577 matrix $X \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}$ to a vector $\bar{X} \in \mathbb{R}^{2n}$. Refer to Fig. 13 for a comparison to the FR
578 algorithm.

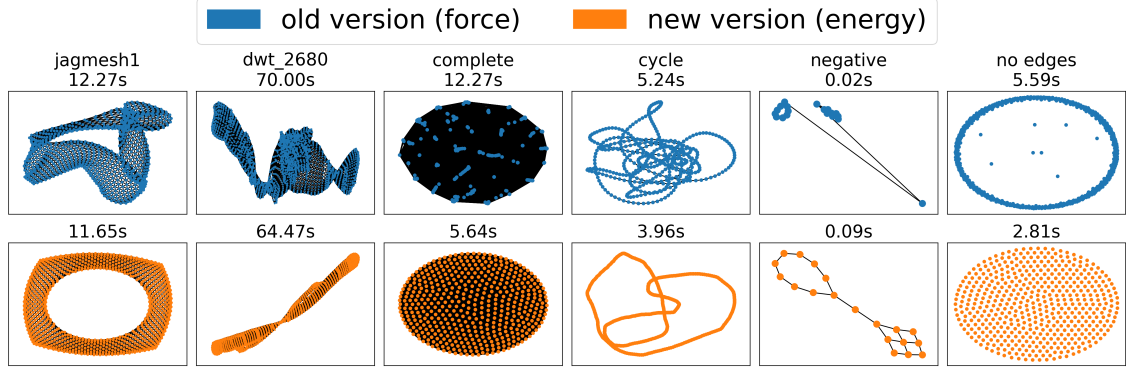


Figure 14: The FR algorithm and L-BFGS algorithm in NetworkX.

A.3 NetworkX Implementation

In this subsection, we explain the details of our NetworkX implementation. Refer to Fig. 14 for a comparison to the FR algorithm. The problem setting considered in NetworkX is similar to that described in Sec. 2, but there are some key differences. First, the number of dimensions is not always two. Since the extension of the method is straightforward, we restrict our discussion to two-dimensional layouts. Other than that, the following differences exist:

- Negative edge weights are allowed.
- Directed graphs are supported, not just undirected graphs.
- The graph is not always connected.

Under these settings, the problem (1) can be unbounded. It means that the optimal solution does not exist in a finite region. When edge weights are negative or the graph is disconnected, i.e., when it consists of $m > 1$ connected components ($V = \bigoplus_{j=1}^m V_j$), the solution may be unbounded, since the farther apart the vertices are, the lower the energy.

To overcome this issue, we do the following suitable modifications. First, when the graph has negative edge weights, one may transform them into non-negative values, for example, by taking their absolute values. Second, when the graph is a directed one, only the sum $a_{i,j} + a_{j,i}$ matters in the formulation, so symmetrization is sufficient. Thus, the directed and possibly negatively weighted adjacency matrix $\tilde{A} = (\tilde{a}_{i,j}) \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n}$ can be transformed into a symmetric matrix $A = (a_{i,j})$, where $a_{i,j} = (|\tilde{a}_{i,j}| + |\tilde{a}_{j,i}|)/2 \geq 0$. Third, we add additional forces to the energy function to prevent the divergence of each connected component. In general, adding terms that attract each group to the center is a common approach to avoid unboundedness. We adopt this approach with the center $x_{\text{center}} = (0.5, 0.5)^\top$, as it is the center of the expected layout bounding box.

Based on Sec. 2, let us define the sum of terms associated with the vertex x_i be Φ_i , which is explicitly given by

$$\Phi_i(x_i) := \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} (\Phi_{i,j}(\|x_i - x_j\|) + \Phi_{j,i}(\|x_j - x_i\|)).$$

The i -th row of the gradient $\nabla \Phi(X) \in \mathbb{R}^{2 \times n}$ is

$$(\nabla \Phi(X))_i^\top = \nabla \Phi_i(x_i) = \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{(a_{i,j} + a_{j,i})\|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{2k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) (x_i - x_j)$$

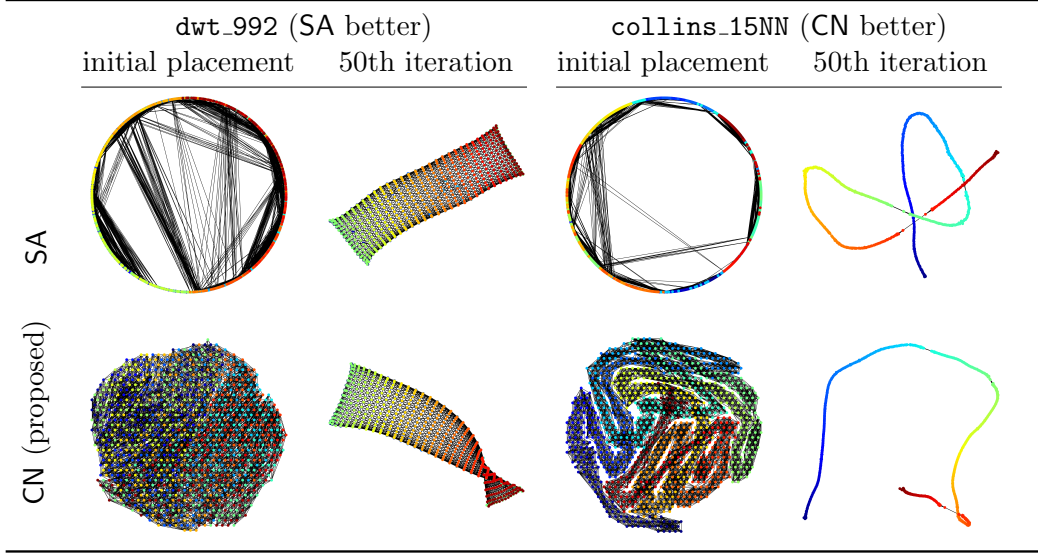


Figure 15: Visualization results showing initial and 50th iteration placements for `dwt_992` and `collins_15NN`.

$$= 2 \sum_{j \in V \setminus \{i\}} \left(\frac{a_{i,j} \|x_i - x_j\|}{k} - \frac{k^2}{\|x_i - x_j\|^2} \right) (x_i - x_j).$$

606 To obtain the final layout while preventing the divergence, we need to minimize $\Phi(X) +$
607 $f_g(X)$, where $f_g(X)$ is the additional term. Let the center of gravity of the j -th connected
608 component V_j ($1 \leq j \leq m$) be $g_j := \frac{1}{|V_j|} \sum_{i \in V_j} x_i$. Then, using some constant $c_g > 0$, we
609 define the additional force as

$$\Phi_g(X) := c_g \sum_{j=1}^m \frac{|V_j|}{2} \|g_j - x_{\text{center}}\|_2^2,$$

610 with the gradient

$$(\nabla \Phi_g(X))_i = c_g (g_j - x_{\text{center}}) \quad \text{where } i \in V_j.$$

611 We can now apply the L-BFGS algorithm to these functions to derive the algorithm.
612 Further implementation details and experimental results are available in [our merged pull](#)
613 [request](#) to the NetworkX.

614 B Additional Experimental Results

615 B.1 Comparison with Other Initializations

616 Next, we conducted experiments to evaluate the performance of the proposed algorithm
617 (CN) compared to random initialization (no prefix) and SA initialization (SA) with various
618 graphs.

619 We used all undirected, connected, non-negative weighted graphs with 1,000 or fewer
620 vertices, which can be generated using the matrices from the Sparse Matrix Collection [8]
621 as adjacency matrices. For fairness, when we compare with SA, we converted the graphs
622 to an unweighted one. It means that we set weights $a_{i,j}$ to 1 if $a_{i,j} > 0$; otherwise, we set
623 it to 0.

For the algorithms with random initial placement, we set $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}} = N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{LBFGS}} = 50$, the same as the default parameter in NetworkX [16]. For the CN algorithms, we set $N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{FR}} = N_{\text{iter}}^{\text{LBFGS}} = 45$, since the preprocessing step is expected to take as long as a few iterations of FR or L-BFGS, as mentioned in Sec. 5.1.

The results are shown in Figs. 7 and 8. The proposed algorithm performed better than random or SA initialization, except for a few cases. As for random initialization, one of such bad cases is **Spectro_10NN** shown in Fig. 9. The proposed algorithm failed to resolve the twist in the initial placement, shown in the figure, leading to a worse result. Still, the average performance of ten seeds for **Spectro_10NN** was almost the same as that of the random initialization. Fig. 15 provides examples for comparison with SA initialization. The proposed algorithm outperformed in **collins_15NN** and underperformed in **dwt_992**.

The interpretation of the results is as follows. First, results in Figs. 7 and 8 strongly support the effectiveness of the proposed algorithm. It successfully untangles the twists, leading to better outcomes with faster convergence. Even when the proposed algorithm performed worse, the difference was insignificant in almost all cases. Secondly, the structural difference between the initial placement and the optimal placement potentially affects the convergence speed. For example, the optimal shape of **collins_15NN** is linear, differing from a circle, resulting in SA's performance being inferior to the proposed algorithm, whereas the opposite holds for **dwt_992**. Although the proposed method utilizes a hexagonal lattice Q^{hex} , alternatives such as Q^{circle} may lead to improved performance of the proposed method in some cases.

Furthermore, although this is a case not considered in Ref. [14], we also conducted experiments with CN and SA for a case where the edge weight $a_{i,j}$ is not necessarily in $\{0, 1\}$. We generated a weighted graph with 100 vertices in three groups and 1000 edges randomly, and if the two vertices were in the same group, we set the edge weight to 1.0; otherwise, we set it to 0.1. It exhibits both strong and weak connections. Fig. 10 shows the difference between the two initializations. When we ignore the edge weights and just solve the problem (2), the graph is just an Erdős–Rényi graph, and thus SA cannot find any meaningful structure in the initial placement. In contrast, the proposed algorithm can identify the graph's structure, and we can observe that the left graph in Fig. 10 is separated into groups, as indicated by the node colors. This result suggests that our proposed algorithm is effective even for weighted graphs, extending the applicability of the preprocessing step.

B.2 Large Graphs

reviewerB からのグラフを追加